

TOPIC 2: RIGHTS AND RESPONSIBILITIES

1. Meaning of Rights

Rights are the freedoms and entitlements that the law and the Constitution guarantee to citizens (and in many cases to all persons). Examples include the right to life, dignity, personal liberty, fair hearing, freedom of expression, freedom of movement, and freedom from discrimination.

2. Meaning of Responsibilities (Duties)

Responsibilities are the obligations that citizens owe to the state and to one another. Examples: obey the law, pay taxes, respect the rights of others, defend the country when required, vote responsibly, and protect public property.

3. Interdependence of Rights and Duties

Rights and duties go together. You cannot fully enjoy your rights if others do not perform their duties (e.g. if people ignore traffic rules, everyone's safety is at risk). Likewise, the state protects rights in return for citizens fulfilling their duties. A good citizen balances claim to rights with performance of duties.

4. Summary

Rights protect the individual; responsibilities sustain the community and the state. They are interdependent: respect for others' rights and fulfilment of duties make rights meaningful for everyone.

End of Topic 2